

Session 20: The Resurrection of the Dead

Key Takeaways

- It appears the Corinthians believe in Jesus' resurrection, but some of them don't believe in the resurrection of everyone.
- Paul says the Corinthians' faith is futile without the resurrection and they are still in their sins. A rejection of the resurrection is an unwillingness to trust the Gospel.
- The Spirit who raised Christ from the dead is also at work in us. Far from bypassing our bodies, this work is about our bodies being taken up into Christ.

The Resurrection of the Dead

Inferring from [1 Corinthians 15:12](#), it looks like the Corinthians believed in the resurrection of Jesus, but "some" of them didn't believe in the resurrection of the dead. These were probably the leaders.

In line with everything we've been looking at, Fee writes, "The problem is that the Corinthians believed that they had already assumed the heavenly existence that was to be, an existence in the Spirit that discounted earthly existence both in its physical and its behavioral expressions" (Fee, 1991).

There is the possibility they thought the body was irrelevant and were effectively dualists. We're not entirely sure where they would have got these ideas from. Craig Keener writes that most Palestinian Jews would have believed in the bodily resurrection of the dead according to [Daniel 12:2](#), but the Greeks would believe in the immortality of the soul. Some Jews would have been influenced by Greek thought and some, like the Sadducees, denied the resurrection (Keener, 2005).

"The key issue has to do with being *pneumatikos*. The Corinthians are convinced that by the gift of the Spirit, and especially the manifestation of tongues, they have already entered into the spiritual, 'heavenly' existence that is to be. Only the body, to be sloughed off at death, lies between them and their ultimate spirituality. Thus they have denied the body in the present, and have no use for it in the future. ... At stake is the biblical doctrine of creation."

Fee, Gordon D. (1991). [The First Epistle to the Corinthians](#). Eerdmans. 492.

The greatest affirmation to us is that creation is good and that we are made good. This is why humanity is worth saving. We are not going to be thrown away, dumped, or destroyed only to come back as something or someone different. Who we are now, the very stuff we are made of, is so precious to God that he will take it and rebirth it, clean and whole. We will be reborn the same person in a Christlike mold.

Look at the number of "ifs" that Paul uses to persuade them of their wrong thinking. In [verse 13](#), he also uses a *reductio ad absurdum* that even Christ hasn't been raised if there's no resurrection of the dead.

The Resurrection of Jesus is Key

The main thrust of Paul's argument is that without the resurrection, faith is futile and we are still in our sins. Denial of the resurrection is a complete denial of the Gospel.

Verse 19 says, "If only for this life we have hope in Christ, we are of all people most to be pitied." It's probable this refers to what the Corinthians are thinking.

Paul responds in verse 20, preaching that Christ's resurrection is the "firstfruits" (Greek: *aparche* / ἀπαρχή). The firstfruits are the beginning of the harvest and something like the first installment. Christ's death and resurrection are first, and it is in him that we are raised. (*Aparche* turns up in Romans 8:23, where Paul talks about "we" as the firstfruits, and in his discussion of Israel in Romans 11:16.)

People Being Baptized for the Dead?

Nobody knows what "baptism for the dead" means, but for a really comprehensive list of possible options, see Gordon Fee's commentary [*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*](#), 765-766.

Fee concludes that there are "a plethora of options, none of which is compelling as a natural reading of the text" (Fee, 1991). We don't have any evidence for vicarious baptism, and people find it distasteful, so commentators tend to rule that out, but maybe the Corinthians were doing that? Keener writes, "Probably Paul's theological shorthand here made clearer sense to the Corinthians than it does to us" (Keener, 2005).

In Adam, In Christ

In verse 22, Paul turns to the Adam-Christ typology, which also appears in Romans 5:12-19, where he compares the two men who stand for all humanity.

Here Paul uses the language of being connected first to one and then to another. The connection of one to another gives humanity both an identity and a state—of being a sinner destined to die and of being made righteous and destined for new life.

Christ becomes the new head of all humanity. Irenaeus uses the term recapitulation, where Christ re-heads the whole of humanity.

Jesus died on the cross and was raised from the dead, and the same power that raised Jesus from the dead lives in us, which is why the resurrection of Christ is the firstfruits.

Romans 8:11 NIV

And if the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies because of his Spirit who lives in you.

Ephesians 1:19-20 NLT

¹⁹ I also pray that you will understand the incredible greatness of God's power for us who believe him. This is the same mighty power ²⁰ that raised Christ from the dead and seated him in the place of honor at God's

right hand in the heavenly realms.

There's no good news for us as embodied human beings without Christ's resurrection from the dead. (In verses 23-24, some see an intermediate kingdom with the use of "then ... then ..." but there's no warrant for that [like Rev. 20:4-6]. The end is a one-off event.)

Reflection Question

How would you summarize Paul's argument for why the resurrection matters for followers of Jesus?